MUTHULAKSHMI REDDY

1886–1968



“IT IS THE STATE AND STATE ALONE THAT CAN EFFECTIVELY BREAK DOWN THE TRADITIONAL CUSTOMS THAT ARE HARMFUL TO THE INDIVIDUAL AND TO SOCIETY.”

An unusual family

Muthulakshmi Reddy was born into an unusual family: her father was the Brahmin principal of a college in Pudukottai (in present-day Tamil Nadu), while her mother was from the marginalized devadasi community. Reddy’s father scandalized society by sending her to school, because girls, especially those with a devadasi background, were usually denied an education at the time. Reddy was academically gifted, and the Maharaja of Pudukottai intervened to allow her to study at the state-run all-male Maharaja College. Muthulakshmi would then go on to join the Madras Medical College, where she defied expectations by specializing in surgery,